



*Thai Foreign Minister Sihasak Phuanketkeow met France's Jean-Noël Barrot in Paris
on February 23, 2026*

Thailand's Diplomatic Manipulation on Border Dispute with Cambodia and Online Scam

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Introduction

The longstanding territorial dispute between Cambodia and Thailand reached a critical flashpoint in early 2026, transitioning from a localized border skirmish into an intense diplomatic struggle. While a fragile ceasefire was brokered in late 2025, the peace has been undermined by Thailand while spreading narratives through media to scapegoat Cambodia.

Within this situation, Thailand is justifying its actions by (1) using its local media to spread fake news and (2) interviews through major media outlet while its forces are still encroaching into Cambodia territory. As Cambodia anticipates the formal return of the definitive 1904–1907 border agreements from France, Thailand has launched a sophisticated diplomatic manipulation, leveraging state visits to Paris and a bid for a seat on the UN Human Rights Council to reshape its global image.

This article examines how Thailand is utilizing international media and diplomatic manipulation to assert justify its encroachment into Cambodia territory, with Thailand specifically maneuvering to prevent France from providing map privileges and necessary technical assistance to help Cambodia resolve border issues with Thailand.

Why Thailand had to take action to reshape its image to justify its encroachment actions into Cambodia territory and discourages France to not actively supporting Cambodia regarding the 1904-1907 Franco-Siamese treaties?

On February 4, 2026, Cambodian Prime Minister Hun Manet specifically asked for access to historical and technical documents, including the original maps from the 1904–1907 treaties, to clarify the border demarcation that originated during the French Protectorate era. The letter was sent while Cambodia was preparing for the inaugural Board of Peace meeting in Washington, D.C., signaled as a move to shift the dispute from military skirmishes to a legal and historical debate. The announcement noted that France had previously indicated a "readiness" to provide these documents, which Cambodia aims to use to prove that current Thai military positions (including the controversial shipping containers) are located on Cambodian soil.

On February 17, 2026, Cambodian Prime Minister Hun Manet told Reuters that Thai forces are occupying Cambodian territory despite a ceasefire agreement between both countries. In his first interview with international media since taking office, the Prime Minister described the border situation as "fragile" and accused the Thai military of encroaching "deep into Cambodian territory" by installing shipping containers and barbed wire in areas previously recognized as Cambodian. These comments were made while he was in Washington to attend the inaugural meeting of U.S. President Donald Trump's Board of Peace, which brokered the December 27, 2025, ceasefire following the worst border fighting in over a decade.

Hun Manet called for Thailand to allow the Joint Boundary Commission (JBC) to resume technical demarcation work to verify facts on the ground and address the displacement of tens of thousands of civilians. In response, Thailand's Ministry of Foreign Affairs and military rejected the allegations, asserting that their troop positions are legitimate de-escalation measures and that the barriers are located within Thai territory to prevent further encroachment.

After that, in Washington, D.C., Prime Minister Hun Manet gave a specialized interview to Fox News Digital on February 19, 2026, where he demonstrated the truth about the encroachment from the Thai military into Cambodia territory. Speaking from the sidelines of the Board of Peace meeting, the Prime

Minister revealed that the situation had escalated into a humanitarian crisis, alleging that Thai forces have fenced off entire villages with shipping containers and barbed wire, preventing over 80,000 Cambodians from returning to their homes.

He pointedly told Fox News that "this occupation goes beyond the area Thailand unilaterally claims," arguing that Thai troops have moved into territory long recognized as Cambodian, even under Thailand's own previous maps. Despite the gravity of these claims, Hun Manet maintained a diplomatic stance, reiterating to the American audience that Cambodia rejects the concept of "using war to end war" and remains committed to the Trump-brokered ceasefire, provided that Thailand adheres to the joint agreement to freeze troop movements and allow civilian resettlement.

Thailand reshaped its image of encroachment of Thai Forces into Cambodia territory through media

In response to Cambodia's media blitz, Thailand launched its own diplomatic manipulation, centered on a high-profile interview with Foreign Minister Sihasak Phuangketkeow on France 24 on February 23, 2026. Speaking from Paris, Sihasak categorically rejected Prime Minister Hun Manet's "occupation" narrative, asserting that the controversial installation of shipping containers and barbed wire occurred strictly within Thai territory as a defensive measure to prevent further encroachment.

While he acknowledged that the December 2025 ceasefire remains "fragile," he shifted the blame onto Phnom Penh, accusing the Cambodian government of "internationalizing" a bilateral issue and spreading misinformation for domestic political gain. To demonstrate a commitment to de-escalation, the Foreign Minister revealed that he maintains a direct line of communication with his Cambodian counterpart via WhatsApp to manage border tensions in real-time.

Meeting between Thailand and France Foreign Minister

According to The Nation media, on February 23, 2026, Thailand's Minister of Foreign Affairs met with French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot in Paris to discuss closer ties, a potential strategic partnership, and regional security issues, including the Thai-Cambodian situation.

During the bilateral talks, Sihasak briefed his French counterpart on the "fragile" status of the ceasefire and clarified the facts regarding the deployment of shipping containers, which he defended as legitimate measures within Thai territory.

While the meeting officially aimed to elevate the two nations' relationship to a "Strategic Partnership" in honor of their 170th diplomatic anniversary, it served as a critical platform for Thailand to commend France's "neutral and constructive role" in regional security. By engaging directly with Paris, the Thai government sought to present a narrative of transparency and peaceful intent, proactively countering Cambodia's efforts to use colonial-era French maps as a tool for international pressure.

Thailand Defence Minister proposed a troops withdrawal from Cambodia border when the truth have been revealed

On the same day of February 23, 2026, Thailand's Defence Minister, General Nattaphon Nakpanich, formally proposed a gradual withdrawal of troops from the Cambodian border, citing the massive financial burden of the ongoing deployment.

During a meeting with the Defence Council, General Nattaphon admitted that maintaining a full-scale military presence along the 798-kilometer border is "operationally unsustainable" and has led to significant overspending. To balance national security with these fiscal constraints, the Minister suggested replacing

active-duty soldiers in certain sectors with enhanced electronic surveillance, high-tech fencing, and the establishment of "veteran villages" to maintain a civilian-military eyes-on-the-ground presence.

However, he emphasized that troops would remain stationed in high-risk, undemarcated zones, specifically those recaptured during the December 2025 clashes, to prevent any tactical disadvantage while the government seeks to stabilize the defense budget.

Thailand's narratives to the international community in the United Nations Human Rights Council

Thailand tried to influence the international community to believe the Thailand's narratives that Thailand is a country with strict rule of law that have no online scams and Thailand is taking serious actions to dismantle the online scams in order to scapegoat other countries especially Cambodia and Myanmar. On February 24, 2026, at the High-Level Segment of the 61st Session of the United Nations Human Rights Council at the Assembly Hall, UN Headquarters in Geneva, Thailand's foreign minister delivered his speech about Thailand commitment into dismantling transnational online scam which he addressed that online scam is allowed to fester because of the lack of rule of law in the countries it operates. This shows that Thailand is not responsible for the online scam operation in its country.

On the other hand, Thailand's foreign minister also stressed the false news that Thailand is not seizing Cambodia territory while make false accusation that Cambodia is provoking while Thailand remains committed to dialogue, but it is also the Thailand's duty to protect its sovereignty and territorial integrity. Moreover, Thailand's foreign minister also tried to make the international community believe that Thailand's top priority is peace by asking Cambodia whether Cambodia wishes to choose the path of peace or the path of continue tensions and conflict.

Conclusion

Thailand's active actions can be interpreted as a strategic effort to shift responsibility and shape international opinion so that other governments see Thailand as reasonable and defensive.

First, Thailand attempted to "clean" its international image by shifting blame onto Cambodia, portraying Phnom Penh as the party escalating tensions through misinformation and the internationalization of a bilateral issue. By accusing Cambodia of politicizing the dispute for domestic purposes, Thai officials sought to weaken the credibility of Cambodia's allegations of encroachment and recast Thailand as a defensive and reasonable actor, effectively using Cambodia as a scapegoat to deflect criticism and reduce reputational damage.

Second, Thailand's meeting with French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot in Paris can be understood as a pre-emptive diplomatic move aimed at limiting Cambodia's historical and legal leverage. Because the 1904–1907 Franco-Siamese agreements and colonial-era maps remain central to Cambodia's territorial arguments, engaging France directly allowed Thailand to influence how Paris interprets or handles these historical documents. By emphasizing France's "neutral and constructive role," Thailand sought to discourage France from actively supporting Cambodia's claims or facilitating renewed attention to the agreements, thereby preventing Cambodia from strengthening its position through historical legal evidence at the international level.